

In both Western and Chinese herbal traditions, it has been used to treat bronchitis, whooping cough, and asthma. The herb's antispasmodic effect extends to the gallbladder, where it helps to improve bile flow. This would partly account for its use in treating jaundice, gallstones, and gallbladder pain, as well as its longstanding reputation as a detoxifying herb. Greater celandine's sedative action does not, however, extend to the uterus—it causes the muscles of this organ to contract. The herb is applied externally to soothe and encourage the healing of skin conditions such as eczema. The yellow latex of greater celandine is applied to warts, ringworm, and malignant skin tumors, which are slowly broken down by the effect of its protein-dissolving enzymes.

! Cautions Use only under professional supervision. Can cause liver damage in rare cases. It is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Chelone glabra (Scrophulariaceae) Balmony

Description Perennial herb growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has narrow leaves and short spikes of creamy-white to purple double-lipped flowers.



Balmony's bile-inducing property makes it useful for gallbladder problems.

Habitat & Cultivation Balmony is native to eastern North America, balmony thrives in habitats such as marshland, wet woodland, and riverbanks. It is harvested when in flower during summer or autumn.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Contains resins and bitters.

History & Folklore Balmony's genus name, *Chelone*, means "tortoise" in Greek, referring to the flower head's supposed resemblance to the head of the tortoise.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A strongly bitter remedy, balmony is principally used to treat gallstones and other gallbladder problems. It stimulates bile flow and has a mildly laxative action. It can be taken to relieve nausea, vomiting, and intestinal colic, and to expel worms. It may also be antidepressant. Balmony is a suitable remedy for children.

Chenopodium ambrosioides (Chenopodiaceae) Wormseed

Description Annual herb growing to 3 ft (1 m) with toothed lance-shaped leaves. Yellow-green flowers in round clusters bloom in summer, producing small black seeds in autumn.

Habitat & Cultivation Wormseed is native to Central and South America and the Caribbean. It has been extensively cultivated in Maryland, and in China.

Parts Used Aerial parts, flowering tops.

Constituents Wormseed contains a volatile oil (up to 90% ascaridol, plus geraniol and methyl salicylate), and triterpenoid saponins. Ascaridol is a powerful worm expellent.

History & Folklore An herbal remedy that has been used for centuries, wormseed was used by the Maya in Central America to expel worms. In the eastern U.S., European settlers employed it for the treatment of worms, especially in children. The Catawba made a poultice from the plant, which they used to detoxify snake bite and other poisonings.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Wormseed is principally known for its ability to expel worms, especially roundworm and hookworm. It is also used in the Americas as a digestive remedy, the leaves being taken to settle colic and stomach pains. Wormseed's muscle-relaxing action has led to its use in the treatment of spasmodic coughs and asthma. Externally, juice expressed from the whole herb is applied as a wash for hemorrhoids.

Related Species Many species of *Chenopodium* are used as foods, and some medicinally. The seeds of *C. rhadinostachyum* are used as food by Aborigines in central Australia. Good King Henry (*C. bonus-*

henricus), a species that is native to Europe, is both eaten as a vegetable and used medicinally to treat anemia.

! Cautions Use only under professional supervision. Wormseed is toxic when taken in overdose. Do not take during pregnancy. The herb is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Chimaphila umbellata (Pyrolaceae) Pipsissewa

Description Evergreen plant with several stems, growing to 8 in (20 cm). Has shiny wedge-shaped leaves and small flat-topped clusters of white flowers tinged with red.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North America, Europe, and Asia, pipsissewa grows in woods and shady places, in sandy soils. The leaves are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Pipsissewa contains hydroquinones (including arbutin), flavonoids, triterpenes, methyl salicylate, and tannins. The hydroquinones have a pronounced disinfectant effect within the urinary tract.

History & Folklore Pipsissewa was much used by Native North Americans to induce sweating and treat fevers, including typhus. European settlers used the herb for rheumatism and for urinary and kidney problems. It was listed in the *Pharmacopoeia of the United States* from 1820 to 1916.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Astringent, tonic, and diuretic, pipsissewa is mainly used in an infusion for urinary tract problems such as cystitis and urethritis. It has also been prescribed for more serious conditions such as gonorrhea and kidney stones. By increasing urine flow, it stimulates the removal of waste products from the body, and is therefore of benefit in the treatment of rheumatism and gout. The fresh leaves of pipsissewa may be applied externally to rheumatic joints or muscles, as well as to blisters, sores, and swellings.

Research In tests on animals, pipsissewa leaves appear to lower blood-sugar levels.

Chionanthus virginicus (Oleaceae) Fringe Tree

Description Deciduous shrub or tree growing to a height of 33 ft (10 m). Has elliptical dark green leaves and long flowering stems with spikes of white flowers. Produces dark blue oval fruits.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the U.S., fringe tree grows from Pennsylvania south to Florida and Texas. It is also now found in eastern Asia, and thrives on riverbanks and in damp